

Q : Can you tell us what Instacluster does?

A: Instacluster helps companies scale their applications massively in the cloud by managing the complex data-related technologies underlying the application – for storage, analytics, messaging and search – with a focus on industry-proven pure open source, highly scalable technologies. We solve the scalability problem and allow the customer to focus on developing great applications.

Q : What is the business model of the company?

A: We charge a flat fee per month per technology, managed per node, for our service. We do not charge any software licence fees since we are running purely open source software. Growth comes from adding new customers and from existing customers growing organically, as their data expands (more data = more nodes under management).

Q : What are some important projects you have worked on till now?

A: We have many customers in the gaming, retail, and finance industries. Dream 11 in India runs its fantasy cricket application on our platform, and Epic Games uses Instacluster for its world-famous Fortnite game, to mention a couple of examples.

Q : What major challenges has the company faced till now?

A: Raising money, as well as talent acquisition and retention are some of our key challenges.

Q : How have you overcome these challenges?

A: The initial rounds of investment came from VCs in Australia. Once we got to a critical mass and were able to demonstrate that our model was working, we were able to attract US dollar investors. We are close to profitability and will not need to raise funds again. Having a base in Australia and at other locations around the world

has helped us to hire and keep talent in places where it is not overly expensive.

Q : How has the growth of the company been in, say, the last one year?

A: Over the last year, it was about 70 per cent, while in the year prior to that we grew a 100 per cent.

Q : What kind of customers are you targeting?

A: We target any company that has a Big Data problem and is running apps in the public or private cloud. We have a lot of customers in the finance, retail and gaming industries, to name a few.

Q : What are your expansion plans for the future?

A: We will continue doubling revenues and adding new technologies to the platform. We plan to establish the company as the open source solutions provider for the data layer, for applications that have massive scale.

Q : What are your India plans?

A: We would like to have an independent India operation within the next 18 months. Currently, we are assessing the market opportunities and our preferred go-to-market strategy.

Q : Are there any immediate targets you want to achieve in the next few months or year?

A: We want to add a MySQL technology to our platform and establish our solution in 20 more of the Fortune 100 accounts (we already have several).

Q : What strategies are you using to drive growth?

A: In order to drive growth, we have to pick the technologies that drive scale (more data means more compute nodes, and hence, higher revenues) and are best in our class. For example, Cassandra is used by the biggest companies in the world, like Apple. Second, we must have a broad and complete platform in order to be a total solutions provider

for our customers. Finally, we need to establish the company as the rock-solid, reliable provider of a managed service. If we do these three things right, the revenue growth and revenue quality will follow.

Q : In your opinion, how are open source companies doing presently?

A: Some companies like Red Hat and MongoDB have had success. Others like Pivotal, Cloudera and Datastax have struggled to continue growing. I think the big problem for these companies is that they tried to commercialise an open source technology which ended up competing with them as the open source version matured. We believe that our model is a much better one for open source than the traditional open core model, which these companies have followed.

Q : Do you think the OSS space can be improved upon? If so, how?

A: Yes. It can be done by embracing and supporting the communities themselves, and by offering the promise of pure open source rather than forking the code to build proprietary technologies. The latter is something that destroys the promise of open source and is what most companies are trying to get away from.

Q : How do you perceive the status of open source in India?

A: It seems to be the best off among all the developing countries as well as those in Asia. It's much better than China, Japan and Korea, for example. I think this is driven by the relatively low cost of engineering resources, the high quality of engineers coming from top universities, and the comfort with English as a common language.

Q : What are your suggestions for India to improve in this space, if any?

A: There should be more companies supporting and contributing to the open source communities. **END** 🐧